

CSCI 131: Introduction to Programming in Python

Fall 2026

Computer Science, College of Arts & Sciences, Widener University • 3 credits

Instructor

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Office Hours

M–F 2:00–3:00 (Thursday on Zoom), and by appointment.

Section	Component	Days & Time	Room
B	Lecture	M, W, F 3:00–3:50	Freedom Hall 322

Course Description

This introductory course is designed for College of Arts and Sciences students with no previous experience in programming. Using the Python language, we work with numbers, strings, lists, dictionaries, and files, using loops, conditionals, user-defined functions, and functions from the Python library.

The course is built around writing programs rather than reading about them. It runs in seven two-week units, and every unit follows the same rhythm:

- **First week:** Monday and Wednesday introduce new material through live coding you are expected to type along with. Friday is a graded programming session.
- **Second week:** Monday continues the topic. Wednesday is a graded programming session. Friday is the test on that unit.

Prerequisites

None. This course assumes no prior programming experience.

Learning Outcomes

By the end of this course, students will be able to:

1. Write, run, and debug Python programs.
2. Trace the execution of a program by hand and predict its output without running it.
3. Identify and solve problems with code.

Required Materials

Textbook. Charles R. Severance, *Python for Everybody: Exploring Data Using Python 3*. py4e.com/book Free. Read it online or download the PDF. We use Chapters 1–10; the later chapters are not part of this course.

Software. All graded programming is done on the classroom machines. If you want to practice at home, install Python 3 and IDLE from python.org/downloads.

Assessment

Component	Weight
Programming assignments	40%
Tests	50%
Attendance	10%
Total	100%

There is no cumulative final.

Grading Scale

Tentatively, letter grades will be assigned based on the following distribution.

A	93–100	B	83–86	C	73–76
A–	90–92	B–	80–82	C–	70–72
B+	87–89	C+	77–79	D	60–69
			F		below 60

Component Descriptions

Programming sessions. Roughly once a week class is run as a lab. A programming problem is assigned and is due by the end of that same period. You work on the classroom machines; I circulate the whole time, and asking me for help is the intended use of the session, not a last resort. Problems are sized so that a student who has kept up finishes comfortably within the period.

These are graded on whether the program works and whether it does so in the way the problem asked.

If you have not finished when the period ends, submit what you have. You may then complete it on your own and resubmit by Monday at 11:59pm for up to 50% of the remaining credit.

Tests. Seven in-class tests, one at the end of each unit, each taking the full period. All are closed-book, closed-note, and taken without devices, calculators, or communication of any kind. You may bring one page of handwritten notes to each test.

Course Policies

Attendance

This course is difficult to pass without coming to class. The material is cumulative and moves quickly, and both the programming sessions and the tests — 90% of your grade — can only be completed in the room. If you must miss a session, get the notes from a classmate before coming to office hours.

Late Work

Programming: see the Monday resubmission window described above; nothing is accepted after that, because the following week's material builds on it. Quizzes close when they close and are not reopened. Tests cannot be made up except by prior arrangement or documented emergency — talk to me as early as you can rather than after the fact.

Classroom Behavior

Feel free to leave the room at any time, but please try not to distract other students. You may eat, drink and be merry so long as it does not disrupt the lecture.

Machines open when we are coding, closed when we are not. Much of the lectures are live coding that you should be typing along with, so the lab machines are in use for most of the period. When I ask for screens down, put them down. Personal laptops are not used for graded work in this room.

Collaboration

Discussing concepts, debugging strategies, and the meaning of a problem with classmates is encouraged. Talking through a bug with the person next to you is a normal part of how programmers work. What you submit must be typed by you. Looking at another student's screen to copy their solution, or letting someone copy yours, is not collaboration. If a classmate helps you solve a problem, name them in a comment at the top of your submission; this is never penalized.

Generative AI

Every graded program in this course is written in this room, during class, on the lab machines, without AI assistance.

Outside of class, use whatever helps you learn. Asking a chatbot to explain an error message you do not recognize, or what a library function does, or to quiz you before a test, is fine. Asking it to write a program you were supposed to write yourself is cheating in this course and it is a waste of your tuition — the skill it removes from you is precisely the one you are here to learn.

You own every line you submit. This applies to any work completed for this course. If you cannot explain or modify what you handed in, it is treated as work you did not write, regardless of whether it is otherwise correct.

If you are unsure whether a particular use is permitted, ask me. Asking is always safe.

Academic Integrity

Refer to the University's [Academic Integrity Policy](#). The Science Division strictly enforces the University's policy on cheating and other forms of academic fraud.

Accessibility and Accommodations

Any student has the right to request reasonable accommodation of a disability under the Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA) and Section 504 of the Rehabilitation Act of 1973. Student Accessibility Services (520 E. 14th Street, 610-499-1266) reviews documentation and student requests for accommodations and authorizes all accommodations on campus.

I understand that disclosure of a disability and advocating for adequate accommodations can be complex. If you have any needs or requests which would improve your experience in my class, please feel free to ask. Because this course has timed in-class work most weeks, please contact me early if extended time is among your accommodations, so that we can arrange it from week 1 rather than retroactively.

Student Support and Well-Being

Widener's Counseling and Psychological Services ([CAPS](#)) offers free, short-term counseling to help students manage stress, navigate life changes, and develop coping skills.

Widener offers [academic advising](#), [coaching](#) and [tutoring](#).

Course Schedule

The course is organized into seven units, covered in the order below. Readings are chapters of *Python for Everybody*. This is a rough plan, pacing may shift as the semester develops, and any changes will be announced in class and posted to Canvas.

Unit	Read	Topic
1	1–2	Variables, expressions, and input/output; program state; strings as data
2	3	Conditionals: booleans, comparison, <code>if</code> / <code>elif</code> / <code>else</code> , nesting
3	5, 8	Loops: <code>while</code> and <code>for</code> , counting and summing patterns, list basics
4	4	Functions: <code>def</code> , parameters and arguments, <code>return</code> , scope
5	8, 6	Lists in depth and strings as sequences: methods, slices, mutation, parsing
6	9, 10	Dictionaries and tuples
7	7	Files: reading, writing, and simple delimited data

Any modifications to this syllabus will be announced in class and on Canvas.